Perceptions of Indians in China

After the Opium Wars (1839–42 between China and Britain, and 1856–60 between China, Britain, and France), the Indian community in China grew substantially. Indians had largely lived in Guangzhou, Tibet, and Xinjiang, but after the wars, they spread out to Hong Kong and Shanghai as well. They were largely traders but also Sikh policemen and watchmen.[15] Their presence led to an increase in disputes and resentments. Parsi traders violated an agreement with Chinese authorities not to sell opium in 1839. They also helped finance the Opium Wars and loaned out ships to the British. In Xinjiang, Indians were involved in various commercial and fiscal disputes. In Shanghai, Sikh policemen and watchmen developed a reputation for being fierce and violent. They and other Indians attracted various racist descriptions referencing their appearance and colour. Indian soldiers under the British fought in the Opium Wars and helped suppress the Taiping and Boxer rebellions. They too attracted all kinds of invidious names and descriptions.[16]

Chinese intellectuals view India

This disdain was to become evident, too, at the level of China's intellectuals and its political elite in the late nineteenth century. The source materials for their knowledge of India came largely from European and Japanese writers (the latter's views often drew on European writings). Wagner in his survey of Chinese attitudes concludes: 'The trope of the unchanging Indian national character that was unable and unwilling to adapt to changing circumstances was already well established in the West by this time [i.e., the early nineteenth century] and became firmly established in the Chinese discussion.'[17] Chinese writers and thinkers got a picture of a timeless rural population, 'divided into castes, addicted to ascetic superstition, religious suicide, and abstruse philosophy'.[18] Indians were feudal and disunited, unable to stand up to foreign invaders, and willing to serve anyone who